Rugged Individualism

Herbert Hoover · campaign speech · New York City · October 22, 1928 · excerpts

Source: Hoover Presidential Library; reprinted in The New Day (1928).

Two weeks before he won the presidency, Hoover gave his major economic-philosophy speech at Madison Square Garden. He contrasted American 'rugged individualism' with what he saw as the European tradition of state paternalism. The speech aged badly: less than a year later the Great Depression began, and Hoover's reluctance to use federal power to address it became the central liability of his presidency.

Connect: Hoover's laissez-faire approach in 1929-33 was consistent with Republican philosophy since McKinley. What broke this consensus by 1932?

Key Passages

On American distinctiveness

> When the war closed, the most vital of all issues both in our own country and throughout the world was whether governments should continue their wartime ownership and operation of many instrumentalities of production and distribution. … We were challenged with a peace-time choice between the American system of rugged individualism and a European philosophy of diametrically opposed doctrines — doctrines of paternalism and state socialism.

On government and business

> We are nearer today to the ideal of the abolition of poverty and fear from the lives of men and women than ever before in any land. … Through liberation from widespread poverty we have reached a higher degree of individual freedom than ever before.

On equality of opportunity

> It is, in fact, our system of opportunity, our system of which has given us our wealth and our individual freedom.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	Prosperity of the 1920s under Republican presidents and laissez-faire policy; Hoover was running for president in 1928 against Democrat Al Smith.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Voters in the 1928 election; Republicans at Madison Square Garden and a national radio audience.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Herbert Hoover, a successful engineer, businessman, and commerce secretary who believed in voluntary cooperation and limited government.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Sourcing — HAPP for 3 docs (1 pt): Practice writing one sentence each of Historical context, Intended audience, Purpose, and POV for Hoover's speech.

2. Identify ONE specific 1930s policy Hoover would have called 'state paternalism.'

3. How does this speech's framing of poverty differ from FDR's First Inaugural five years later?